as monosodium glutamate (MSG), an entire vocabulary of ingredients has appeared on the back labels of packaged foods (see accompanying story, *The New Dirty Dozen*). These include ultra-processed additives such as maltodextrin, glucose-fructose syrup, protein isolates, emulsifiers, modified starches, unfamiliar sweeteners and protein supplements.

The need of the hour is for food regulators to be more proactive, like Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) commissioner Tukaram Mundhe is doing with his crackdown on restaurants that cook or serve food in unhygienic conditions (see accompanying report, *Grilling the Eateries*).

THE FRONT LABEL BATTLE

Experts say consumers need clear, meaningful labelling to make informed choices about what they eat. Not all packaged foods are harmful, nor is information about their contents entirely absent. Packaged foods in India are required to disclose nutritional information, and they do. The debate is over where that information appears and how clearly it is presented. For, consumers rarely stand in supermarket aisles calculating grams of sugar or sodium against recommended daily allowances. Dr Arun Gupta, convenor of the Nutrition Advocacy in Public Interest (NAPi), points out that a shopper may spend just four to 20 seconds selecting a product. That makes the front of the packet enormously valuable territory.

"The real estate of the front of the pack is important," says Rohit Kumar Singh, former secretary in the consumer affairs, food and public distribution ministry. "Nobody's looking at the back and the fine print." His point goes to the heart of the FOPL debate. Food companies have long understood the power of the front of the packet, which is why their most attractive visuals and persuasive descriptions appear there. Health advocates argue that information essential to assessing those claims deserves equally prominent space.

Singh agrees, saying detailed nutritional information can remain on the back of the pack or accessed via a QR code. But, he says, "The larger principle needs to be to keep the front label simple enough for a consumer to understand, in a split second, whether the product is high in sugar, fat or whatever else, while keeping the underlying regulatory architecture scientifically rigorous."

Evidence suggests such warnings can make a difference. A 2022 randomised field experiment published by the Multidisciplinary Digital Publishing Institute (MDPI) involved 2,869 Indian consumers choosing between several FOPL formats—from a hexagonal warning label, a Health Star Rating, to a traffic-light system using green, yellow and red. A majority preferred the plain warning hexagon proclaiming 'High in Sugar' or 'High in Salt'.

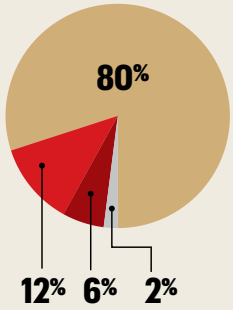
The FSSAI has now moved towards red hexagonal warning labels for products that cross prescribed thresholds for sugar, salt and saturated fat. While the principle appears simple, the debate over its execution is anything but. The first question? What merits a warning? The FSSAI first proposed that a product carry one only if it breached the prescribed limits for at least two of the three nutrients—added sugar, salt or saturated fat.

NAPi's Gupta calls this a "gaping loophole". A cola or other sugary products, for instance, may contain enormous amounts of sugar while being low in fat and salt. Under such a rule, they could escape a warning altogether. Health advocates ask an obvious question: if one ingredient is present at an unhealthy level, why should a product have to contain excessive amounts of another before consumers are alerted?

There is a similar concern over the FSSAI's proposal for phased implementation. Products high in two or more

WHAT CONSUMERS WANT

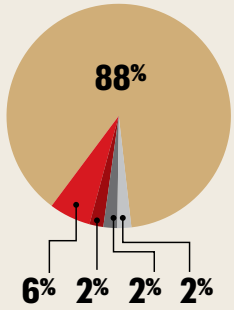
A large majority feels the FSSAI should implement warning labels from Day 1 of the rollout if a product is high in even one of the three: sugar, salt or saturated fat



- Require a warning label from the very beginning if a product is high in even one of the three nutrients
- Implement the FSSAI's proposed two-phase approach
- Require warnings only when a product is high in two or more nutrients
- Can't say

Responses **23,516**

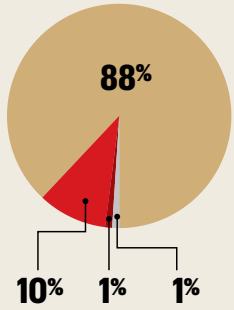
Nearly 90% want food and beverage companies to implement the Front-of-Pack Labelling with warnings within six months



- Within 6 months
- Within 12 months
- Within 18-24 months
- Longer than 24 months
- Can't say

Responses **20,068**

As many as 88% want the warning labels to be large and clearly visible; only 10% are fine with the FSSAI's recommendation of it being just one point larger than the back label font



- It should be large, clearly visible and immediately noticeable when looking at the front of the packaged food
- FSSAI's proposed size is sufficient
- The warning can be smaller as long as it is present
- Can't say

Responses **23,491**

Source: Survey by LocalCircles that received 108,000 responses across 328 districts in September 2026